

Structure, Purpose & POV - Study Guide

A map of how organization, purpose, perspective, and rhetorical choices work together.

Big idea

Strong readers do more than understand what a passage says. They notice how the writer arranged it, why each part is there, whose perspective is represented, and what specific choices accomplish.

The six skills

Skill	Core question	Best evidence
Paragraph / section function	What job does this part perform?	target paragraph plus neighboring sections
Text structure	How are the major ideas organized?	relationship across several paragraphs
Transitions & signal words	What relationship connects these ideas?	logic before and after the transition
Author purpose	What is the writer trying to accomplish?	audience, content, tone, selected details
Point of view / perspective	Whose view is this and what does it emphasize?	attribution, narration, evaluative language
Rhetorical technique	What does this choice achieve?	technique plus its local and larger effect

A single passage can test several skills

Example paragraph

A council report first describes long waits at two bus stops. It then gives temperature readings, quotes one older rider, and proposes shade canopies at the busiest locations. However, the final paragraph notes that utility lines may limit where supports can be installed.

- Function: the final paragraph qualifies the proposal with a practical limitation.
- Structure: problem -> evidence -> solution -> limitation.
- Transition: however signals contrast or qualification.
- Purpose: explain and support a targeted shade proposal.
- Perspective: the rider quotation adds lived experience but is not automatically the author's own view.
- Rhetoric: the quotation makes an abstract comfort problem concrete.

Fast decision tree

1. If the question points to one paragraph or sentence, ask what job that part performs.
2. If it asks how the passage is organized, map the relationship among sections.
3. If a blank or transition is involved, identify the relationship before choosing the word.
4. If it asks why the writer created the text or included a detail, analyze purpose.
5. If it asks who believes or notices something, trace the perspective source.
6. If it asks about a technique, explain what the technique achieves, not just its name.

Cross-skill traps

- Summary instead of function.
- Topic instead of purpose.
- One signal word instead of whole-text structure.
- Quoted speaker mistaken for author.
- Device named without effect.
- A smooth-sounding transition that expresses the wrong logical relationship.

How the skills connect

- Structure tells you how the major ideas are arranged; paragraph function tells you what one part contributes inside that arrangement.
- Purpose explains what the writer is trying to accomplish; rhetorical technique explains how a specific choice helps accomplish it.
- Perspective identifies whose view is represented; transitions help show the logical relationship between that view and surrounding ideas.